



Proving mettle: Sachin Siwach in action during his 60kg gold-winning campaign at the World Boxing Cup Finals in Greater Noida, his most assured performance at the elite level so far. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA

Uzbek Aziza Zokirova to deliver a morale-boosting performance.

World champions Minakshi Hooda (48kg) and Jaismine Lamboria (57kg), who beat tough opponents despite nursing a left shoulder issue, and former World champion Nikhat Zareen (51kg), who ended her long wait for an international medal, pushing themselves to secure the yellow metal, was a heartening sign.

World Championships silver medallist Nupur Sheoran (80+kg) completed the list of seven Indian women gold medallists.

Women's head coach D. Chandralal, who has been replaced by former High Performance director Santiago Nieva due to the BFI's keenness to win Olympic medals, advocated a step-by-step approach from here, beginning with the Asian Championships before shifting focus to the Commonwealth Games and Asian Games.

Chandralal said that since most

of the top Indian women were tall counter-punchers relying on hitting and moving, it would be necessary to strengthen their legs. "For long-range boxers, we should put loads on their legs. We put belts on their ankles and made them do more leg work. We made them do weight training like the athletes so that they got solid legs," said Chandralal.

"In boxing lingo, we say a boxer should have a horse's legs, not an elephant's legs."

Among the men, former World youth champion Sachin Siwach (60kg) posted convincing victories to win gold and record his best performance at the elite level so far.

Hitesh Gulia (70kg) stunned Japan's double World Championships medallist and Asian Games champion Sewon Okazawa and Kazakh pro boxer Nurbek Mursal on his way to the top honour.

Men's head coach Yadav, who is also set to get replaced by a foreigner, said he was happy that the boxers faced strong opponents in decent draws. He was delighted to see Sachin's improved footwork, which enabled the southpaw to avenge his defeat to Kyrgyzstan's Paris Olympics silver medallist

Munarbek Seibtbek Uulu at the Olympic qualifier, in the WBCF title clash.

"In the Brazil World Cup, Sachin fought despite being sick, and I had to throw in the towel to save him. This performance will boost his confidence. Hitesh was the next best," said Yadav.

According to Yadav, silver medallists Jadumani Singh (50kg), Pawan Bartwal (55kg), Abhinash Jamwal (70kg) and debutant Ankush Panghal (80kg) had it in them to produce even better results.

Overall, Yadav said the boxers needed to raise their fitness levels and must be trained to tackle highly physical Central Asian boxers. "The Kazakh and Uzbek boxers tire the opposition out with their rough game. It's part of their training. We need to adopt a similar training pattern. The boxers must work hard; we can only take the horse to the water," he said.

Yadav also appealed to the BFI to host at least one international event every year so that Indian boxers would be motivated to give their best on home turf and draw encouragement from such performances.

After the Indian boxers returned from the Paris Olympics without a medal, the BFI is keen to make amends at LA28. With BFI chief Ajay Singh promising to leave no stone unturned, the federation is keen to rope in the best coaching staff to get the best out of the Indian boxers. The federation is clear about its approach for LA28. "We will focus on the weight categories where we are strong. Besides, we will try to prepare two to three boxers in each weight to encourage competitiveness and achieve bench strength," said BFI executive director Col. Arun Malik, who closely tracks the boxers' progress.

Despite facing challenges due to internal squabbles, the BFI, which is keen on prioritising women's boxing for LA28, would do well to stick to a concrete plan so that the boxers can make the country proud in the bigger events lined up over the next few years.